



India wants its own WhatsApp

The Indian government is reportedly planning to build its own WhatsApp-like chat platform. <https://digit.in/july19-92>



Google wants medical data

The tech giant has been accused of inappropriate access to medical data in lawsuit. <https://digit.in/july19-93>

HP Spectre x360 2019

A yearly CPU and aesthetics update

The brand name “Spectre” has come a long way in the history of HP mobile computing devices. Today, Spectre still represents HP’s slimmest, lightest, and most premium laptops.

Build and Design

Spectre devices usually appear sleek and sharp, and this no is no exception. The Spectre 2019 body’s has an all-aluminium double-chamfered finish trimmed edges on either side of the display hinge. One edge has a USB-C port, and the other houses the power button. The new Spectre x360 feels fairly sturdy in the hands. At 1.32 kilograms, it is quite lightweight too.

Display, Audio and I/O

The HP Spectre x360 has a 13.3-inch touchscreen display with FHD resolution. The IPS WLED-backlit panel is protected by Corning Gorilla Glass NBT. According to HP, the display has a maximum brightness of 300 nits and a pixel count of 166 pixels per inch. The laptop comes bundled with an HP Pen stylus. Pressing F1 on the keyboard enables (and disables) HP Sure View, a privacy guarding feature.

The colours appeared full and rich while browsing the web and watching videos. The brightness is sufficient for most indoor spots. The display is positively responsive to touches. There’s minimal latency during inputs and the palm rejection feature works wells.

Sound from the laptop’s speakers are underwhelming, even though the speakers are Bang & Olufsen. Tracks like Starboy by The Weeknd and One Minute to Midnight by ZHU sound



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tinny and unrefined. Bass is neither heard nor felt from the device. However, they’re quite loud. These speakers are good for vocals.

The Spectre has a single USB-A 3.1 Gen 2 port and two USB-C 3.1 Gen 2 ports, a 3.5mm audio jack, and a microSD card slot.

In addition, there’s a physical switch to turn the webcam off. Those who prefer fingerprint authentication can use the fingerprint scanner just below the keyboard.

Keyboard and Touchpad

The keyboard remains unchanged from last year’s model. It sports two-stage backlit unit. The keycaps feel too small and oddly spaced. They could have used a shallow dimple on the top surface for easier identification. On the bright side, the feedback from the keys are not bad. The keyboard also gets dedicated keys for Home, End, Page Up, and Page Down functions.

The Synaptics-driven touchpad on the Spectre x360 does not support all the multi-finger taps and swipes.

Performance

Sadly, we do not see an Intel 9th Gen chip on the Spectre x360. Instead, we see a “Whiskey Lake R” refresh of the 8th Gen Core series CPUs. The review unit was powered by an Intel i7-8565U

Quad-core CPU with a base clock speed of 1.8GHz. The RAM on the review unit was a standard 16GB, and the solid-state storage, 512GB.

The review unit fared well on our benchmark tests. On PCMark 8’s Accelerated Creative test, the Spectre scored 3702 points. On CrystalDisk-Mark’s storage speed test, it scored a sequential read speed of 3124.9 MB/s and a sequential write speed of 531 MB/s, which is astonishingly fast.

In everyday use scenarios, the review unit worked splendidly. The Spectre managed multitasking on applications quite well. The laptop ran multiple instances of some apps across many virtual desktops without breaking a sweat. The laptop even handled simultaneous background downloads and app installations without any hiccups.

Battery

The HP Spectre x360 comes with an inbuilt quad-cell 61Wh lithium-ion polymer battery. On our standard battery benchmark test, the review unit lasted 4 hours, 17 minutes, which is not a significant jump over last year’s model. In everyday use scenarios, its battery fell from full charge to 54 percent in less than three hours. During the tests, Wi-Fi and Bluetooth were left enabled, and the laptop was used moderately. Expect the device to last around six hours on a single charge.

HP Spectre x360 2019 Verdict

The Spectre x360 remains true to its character, which is a lean, mean business machine. The new Intel Core i7 CPU keeps the Spectre up to date and helps boost battery life. The design is also largely improved. However, apart from the CPU and design there’s little that’s new about the Spectre x360.

—Vignesh Giridharan

SPECIFICATIONS

PROCESSOR: Intel Core i7-8565U | RAM: 16 GB DDR4 | STORAGE: 512GB NVMe PCIe SSD | DISPLAY: 13.3-inch 1080p | I/O: 2x USB 3.0 Type-C, 1x USB 3.1 Gen 2, 3.5mm audio | BATTERY: 61Wh

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